will be taken by a political [read elected] government." Sources say he was particularly incensed about "foreign actors" attempting to influence sensitive national decisions—an apparent jab at NSA Rahman.

This isn't the first time national sovereignty has entered the spotlight. Even before her ouster, Sheikh Hasina had alleged that "a nation of white individuals" was pressuring her to cede control of the St. Martin's Island area, a charge she has been repeating in her voice messages to party loyalists, claiming that Yunus was "trying to sell off the country".

A Tense Standoff

Zaman and Yunus have been circling each other since the latter took over. The army chief was appointed on June 23 last year, just weeks before the uprising. To top it off, he is married to a distant cousin of Hasina's. Many believe Yunus has tried to neutralise the general's influence by elevating Rahman from 'high representative' to NSA. As a government source notes, "Gen. Zaman has been firm in thwarting a probe into the military's activities. Yunus was hoping to bring him under scrutiny via Rahman."

Yet Zaman's cautious handling of the political transition has won him some respect. His critics, though, point to how he refrained from stopping the violence and, indeed, detaining the Hasina leadership. A source close to the general, though, justifies the actions. "By allowing safe passage to Hasina, he helped prevent bloodshed. Neither were people murdered on the streets nor was Hasina attacked by the mob," he points out.

Mainstream politicians—including from the BNP—are also appreciative of his call for timely polls. As political researcher and historian Altaf Parvez put it, "Waker-uz-Zaman is a unique case. He's not trying to stage a coup. Rather, he wants fair elections, which is the demand of most Bangladeshis. I don't think South Asia has [ever] seen such a case." But he does add a note of caution. "This is a crucial time for the people of this country, he says. "Any small incident can snowball into something big. People here have accepted that, for some time, we will have a period of uncertainty."

GENERAL DRAWS THE LINE

- **Declares that Bangladesh must have a newly elected government in place by January 1, 2026**
- **Opposes interim government's plans to privatise Chattogram port, establish a Myanmar aid corridor; insists such decisions must be taken by an elected regime**
- **Warns against "foreign influence" on national policy-making, indirectly criticising advisors like Khalilur Rahman**
- **Signals disapproval of rising Islamist influence, flags controversial appointments linked to extremist networks**

Islamist Undercurrents

Indian observers have seized upon these developments across the border. Harsh Vardhan Shringla, former ambassador to Bangladesh, says, "Today, through the guise of a students' movement, Islamists have come to power in Dhaka. Prof. Yunus is the face, but the real force is an Islamist agenda hostile to India's security."

Recent intelligence assessments support this view. A core group of Islamist extremists are reportedly operating out of Dhaka, with active links to Hizb ut-Tahrir, Islamic State and the Ansarullah Bangla Team. Reports say they organise street protests under the Towhidi Janata banner and orchestrate blockades targeting police stations and prisons. Over 50 public religious seminars have been held in the past six months, which, according to reports, doubled up as recruitment drives for the extremists. The Islamists got a shot in the arm when, on May 27, the Bangladesh Supreme Court acquitted Jamaat leader A.T.M. Azharul Islam, a death row convict charged with crimes against humanity during the 1971 Liberation War. The verdict has sparked outrage among the pro-liberation and other political forces.

Meanwhile, India has also been making strategic moves, widely seen as a response to Dhaka's growing proximity to China and Pakistan. On May 17, it redirected all land route imports from Bangladesh—worth $770 million annually—through seaports, effectively pricing them out of its border markets. For Dhaka, the impact may be severe: small exporters relying on cheap, fast land routes to India's eastern states now face delays and higher costs. The message is clear—India will weaponise trade to assert its strategic priorities and signal that market access hinges on political alignment. On the other side, Yunus is also amplifying the bad neighbour narrative, alleging an 'Indian conspiracy' to destablilise his government at a meeting with the political party Nagorik Oikya.

Even the ousted Awami League appears to be recalibrating. Speaking from an undisclosed location, party general secretary Obaidul Quader says, "I do not want to blame the army or the army chief...let us look forward." He refused to call Zaman a traitor unlike many of his colleagues and believes the current turmoil may turn out to be "a blessing in disguise for the Awami League and the people of Bangladesh".

Whether the Yunus administration holds credible elections and step aside by December 2025 is debatable. But with the military drawing clear red lines, resurgent Islamists pushing their agenda, political stakeholders growing restless, and cracks emerging within civil institutions and the economy, Bangladesh's future remains in ferment—calm on the surface, but pregnant with peril. ■